

Computing for Productivity

It is amazing how quickly computers have moved from 3 MHz to 3 GHz processors. Yet, in terms of capability they have mostly moved to prettier looking ways of doing the same old things.

A computer is your primary filing cabinet, and as the repository and medium of a large part of your business communication, it must move up to being a better tool to manage, infer, draw inter-connections and retrieve that information. What are now called 'Personal Information Management' software, are like what Notepad is to Word—much needs to improve. The good news is that the technology for all of this already exists, and stand-alone tools are currently accomplishing some of these. But to be truly useful, these functions must be part of a whole system:

Search: Why does looking for information you know you have on your PC take so much longer than finding information online? Because your PC isn't spending any of its idle time indexing your data. Search technologies to solve this issue have existed for decades, but it is not something we have expected from our desktops yet. Standalone tools such as X1 help, and this is likely to be the first task that is integrated well.

Organise: The battle with spam has demonstrated the power of Bayesian processing. Tools such as Popfile can learn to auto-magically sort your incoming e-mail into as many categories as you like, based on your feedback. Why do we still need to think about which folder to save a file in? Just drop it into 'My Documents' and it should become part of your self-organising filing system.

Remember: How often have you realised you know when you have seen some information, but you don't know where? Like a history for browsing, there should be a history for files and folders usage, for chatting and so on, all accessible in one place—the System History. Tying a search of all your information repositories—be it e-mail programs, browser history, or documents—to time, makes for a powerful tool that leads into...

Contextualise: Combine histories through all your communications and documents in a coordinated manner. Pull up an e-mail and you see what Web pages you were seeing at the time, what documents were open, a slice of any instant messenger conversations and a list of all your digital communications with that individual. Sounds like a utopian goal, but the Ximian 'Digital Dashboard' project proposes to do this, and has just released the first bits.

Extend: Going forward, an increasing volume of digital data that we produce and consume will be rich media—text and audio or video interleaved. Any self-respecting personal information management system will have to deal with this well. Indexing sound is a possibility, as is extracting and comparing images to identify and connect the participants of video-phone conversations or meetings. However, in the realistic nearer term, this would involve connecting textual data to points in an audio or video clip. Take a look at this near future with OneNote 2003 SP1.

These five are critical functions that a computer must be able to perform soon, or end up complicating our work rather than complementing it.



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